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UAE LEADERS MEET KING OF BAHRAIN

President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan along with His Highness Sheikh Mohammed Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, met King Hamad Bin Eisa Al Khalifa of Bahrain on Saturday. The leaders reviewed various aspects of bilateral cooperation between the UAE and Bahrain. They also exchanged views on several regional and international issues of mutual interest. The meeting was attended by Sheikh Hamdan Bin Mohammed Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Crown Prince of Dubai, Deputy Prime Minister and Minister of Defence of the UAE.

Dubai makes business setup faster, easier

84% rise in business
licences issued
during 2023-25

DUBAI

BY ASHFAQ AHMED
Managing Editor

Business activity is booming in Dubai, with the number of business licences issued between 2023 and 2025 being 84 per cent higher than the number issued between 2020 and 2022, according to the Dubai Business Registration and Licensing Corporation (DBLC), part of the Dubai Department of Economy and Tourism (DET).

During the first half of 2026, 58,337 licences were issued across Dubai's mainland and free zones, while 173,652 licences were renewed.

Expanding operations

Total licence issuance and renewal transactions exceeded 230,000 during the period, highlighting not only the continued arrival of new businesses but also the confidence of existing companies in expanding their operations in Dubai.

Ahmad Khalifa Al Qaizi Al Falasi, CEO of DBLC, told *Gulf News* in an exclusive interview that the authority is now focused on transforming the

investor journey, shaping legislation and policy, and connecting government entities and the private sector through an integrated digital environment.

Al Falasi said the growth is particularly evident in future-focused sectors, including fintech and artificial intelligence, supported by Dubai's regulatory environment and digital infrastructure.

At the centre of the emirate's digital transformation is the 'Invest in Dubai' platform, which DBLC describes as a unified digital channel for establishing businesses and conducting economic activities.

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EU CONDEMNS IRAN ATTACKS ON REGIONAL NATIONS

*Oil exports remain sharply
down amid Hormuz battle*

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.

Senior Associate Editor

The European Union yesterday strongly condemned Iran's latest attacks on the UAE, Kuwait, Jordan and Saudi Arabia, expressing alarm at the latest military escalation in the Middle East.

The EU said it was alarmed by the latest military escalation and also deplored attacks on Saudi commercial vessels passing through the Strait of Hormuz, saying they violated international law. It called for de-escalation and full implementation of UN Security Council Resolution 2817, urging all sides to avoid actions that could further threaten regional security and undermine efforts towards a lasting settlement. The bloc also called for civilians to be protected in accordance with international humanitarian law.

The appeal came as President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan received a phone call from Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan. The leaders discussed regional developments and stressed the need to intensify efforts to strengthen Middle East security and stability and advance lasting peace.

Meanwhile, former US De-

fence Secretary Leon Panetta warned that the conflict could continue for another six months. "I think the likelihood is this war is going to continue for another six months without being resolved," Panetta told *The Guardian*, describing Washington and Tehran as locked in a stalemate with neither side apparently prepared to negotiate or surrender.

Iran warning

Amid escalating tensions, Iran's top negotiator Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf warned of swifter and more forceful retaliation against further US attacks after Tehran targeted American warships. His comments came as TankerTrackers said Middle East crude exports in August remained 39 per cent below the January-February baseline of 18.5 million barrels per day. Exports had fallen as much as 67 per cent below the baseline in May.

The US said it destroyed three Iranian oil tankers on Saturday after attempted missile attacks on US naval vessels. Iran's Revolutionary Guards said they targeted US-linked ships. The renewed exchanges come amid a deadlock, with Iran maintaining its grip on the Strait of Hormuz while Washington continues its counter-blockade of Iranian ports.

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